

Sceptics: Pyrrho and his followers



It is in the nature of philosophical enquiry for assumptions to be questioned, but Pyrrho and his followers, the sceptics, made doubt the central principle of their philosophy. Like Plato, they believed that human senses cannot be relied upon, and therefore that we cannot know how things are, only how they appear. Consequently any evidence we have for an assertion, since it comes from our senses, is equally unreliable. This does not mean that it is wrong, but that it could be wrong or right. In logical argument, this meant that the truth of the premises is in doubt and can only be established by arguments based on other unreliable premises, *ad infinitum*: there can be no

ultimate certainty. So, they reasoned, for every assertion, a completely opposing and contradictory assertion can be made with equal justification. Scepticism can be seen as an extreme form of relativism, and in its purest form denies the validity of any philosophical argument. Despite this, it was to have a strong influence, especially on the philosophy of science and the logic-based philosophies of the 20th century.